A few basic ideas were deeply ingrained into every Hindu, whether he lived up to them or not. Among these commonly-held beliefs were two four-fold divisions. The first was the organisation of life into four stages, or *ashrama*s: these were *brahmacharya*, the bachelor existence, a time to be spent learning and acquiring mastery over the essential disciplines needed to lead a meaningful life; then *grihastha*, the life of a householder, when one married, procreated, and assumed the responsibilities of family life; then *vanaprastha*, when one retired and retreated to the forest to lead a life of contemplation in harmony with nature; and finally, sannyas, the stage of renunciation of all worldly ties, at which one seeks one's ultimate merger with Brahman, the spirit suffusing the cosmos.

The four stages of life also related to the four ends of life, the Purusharthas, that every Hindu had to pursue: *dharma*, the moral code (discussed more fully later), *artha*, prosperity or material well-being, *kama*, desire for pleasure and gratification, and ultimately *moksha*, or the salvation that comes from ultimate self-realisation, the fulfilment of which is the purpose of each individual life.

These stages and ends of life in Hinduism embraced an all-encompassing idea of human needs in a comprehensive vision. Every person needs to learn and to earn; to have sex, food and money; to love, to nurture, to assume responsibility; each individual also has a shared concern for the common good and an indefinable curiosity about the unseen, about that which can only be experienced and not understood through words. All of these urges coexist in all of us; they overlap and interact with each other; we pursue them systematically or randomly, or we stumble across them, but they are present in each of our lives in an interdependence of which we are barely conscious but which the Hindu *rishi*s fully appreciated. The common expression '*mata, pita, guru, daivam'* encapsulates the human journey—one is first, from birth, totally dependent on the mother, then exposed to the outer world by the father, then taught and guided by the guru, until one finally finds God.

The Hindu appreciation of life saw it whole, recognised the supreme ends of life and the stages needed to progress towards their achievement. It did not seek to suppress or deny the normal lust for sex, wealth or